

confusing number of product editions, including two aimed at phones – a Windows Mobile 2003 Smartphone Edition and a Windows Mobile 2003 Pocket PC Phone Edition. Why this differentiation? Smartphones, at the time, were seen as very small devices with tiny screens, whereas Pocket PC Phones would have larger touch-based screens that more closely resembled the previous generation PDA devices. This distinction eventually disappeared.

Over time, Windows Mobile grew more powerful and functional, but it also suffered at the hands of its more aggressive competitors. The first was Research in Motion, or RIM, a Canadian company that grew to great success on the back of its “push” e-mail functionality. Push allows users of



The rise of the smartphones

RIM’s BlackBerry smartphones to access their email (as well as contacts, calendar and tasks) over the air, directly and not via synchronisation, which is slower and requires a wired connection between the device and the user’s PC. Microsoft responded to RIM by adding push functionality to Windows Mobile, but by then it was too late: RIM began dominating the corporate market for smartphones, especially in the United States, a position it has yet to relinquish.

And then, in 2007, the world changed dramatically. Apple announced and then released its iPhone smartphone. By targeting consumers rather than business users, and focusing on functionality such as media playback and internet browsing, Apple opened up smartphones to a whole new market. It didn’t hurt that the iPhone, along with its software, was beautiful to look at, fun to use and featured advanced multi-touch technology that the competition struggled to duplicate for years. The iPhone took off for good once Apple opened up the device to third-party development and established a thriving Apps Store from which users could download and, for paid apps, purchase selections from an ever-growing collection of apps. Today, no modern smartphone platform – including Windows Phone – is considered complete without such a store